

The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra of the Perfection of Wisdom Called the Diamond Cutter

Āryavajracchedikā-nāma-prajñāpāramitā-mahāyāna-sūtra · Toh 16 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་ཕྱི་རལ་དུ་ཞུ་བའི་པ་རྫོགས་ཅན་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ་བའི་པ་ཆེ་པའི་མཛན།

The Diamond Cutter Perfection of Wisdom Sūtra, known in Sanskrit as the Ārya-vajracchedikā-prajñāpāramitā-mahāyāna-sūtra and in Tibetan as the Phags pa shes rab kyi pha rol tu phyin pa rdo rje gcod pa, is one of the most celebrated texts in the Mahāyāna Buddhist tradition. It belongs to the Perfection of Wisdom class of sūtras and teaches the nature of emptiness and non-attachment, famously using the image of a diamond or thunderbolt that cuts through illusion to convey how wisdom severs all conceptual clinging, including attachment to the very teachings themselves. The text is structured as a dialogue between the Buddha and his disciple Subhūti, set in the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada near Śrāvastī, and unfolds through a series of penetrating questions and answers about the nature of bodhisattvas, merit, and ultimate reality. It is Toh 16 in the Kangyur, preserved among the Perfection of Wisdom sūtras, and has been among the most widely studied and revered scriptures across the Mahāyāna world for well over a millennium.

In the language of India: Ārya-vajracchedikā-nāma-prajñāpāramitā-mahāyāna-sūtra. In the Tibetan language: The Noble Great Vehicle Sūtra of the Perfection of Wisdom Called the Diamond Cutter.

I prostrate to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in Śrāvastī, in the Jeta Grove, the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada, together with a great Saṅgha of one thousand two hundred and fifty monks, and with very many great bodhisattvas.

Then, at the time of the morning meal, the Blessed One dressed, put on his outer robe and took up his almsbowl, and entered the great city of Śrāvastī for alms. When the Blessed One had gone through the great city of Śrāvastī for alms and had finished his meal, taking his food at the end, he performed the act of eating. He set down his almsbowl and outer robe, washed his feet, arranged his seat, and sat down cross-legged, holding his body upright, and remained with mindfulness brought to the fore.

Then many monks came to where the Blessed One was, approached him, and, bowing their heads to the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated the Blessed One three times and sat down to one side.

And at that time the venerable Subhūti was there, seated within that very assembly. Then the venerable Subhūti rose from his seat, draped his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, and, facing the Blessed One, pressed his palms together and said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, it is wonderful, it is remarkable, how much the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha has benefited the bodhisattvas, the great bodhisattvas with the highest benefit, and how much the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly awakened buddha has entrusted the bodhisattvas, the great bodhisattvas with the highest entrustment. Blessed One, it is wondrous. Sugata, it is wondrous. Blessed One, how should those who have genuinely entered the vehicle of the bodhisattva abide? How should they practice? How should they master the mind?"

When this was said, the Blessed One declared this to the venerable Subhūti: "Excellent, Subhūti, excellent! Yes, Subhūti, that is so, that is just so. The Tathāgata has benefited the bodhisattvas, the great bodhisattvas with the highest benefit. The Tathāgata has entrusted the bodhisattvas, the great bodhisattvas with the highest entrustment. Therefore, Subhūti, listen and take it thoroughly to heart, for I shall explain to you how those who have genuinely entered the vehicle of the bodhisattva should abide, how they should practice, and how they should master the mind."

"Yes, Blessed One, so be it," replied the venerable Subhūti, and he listened attentively to the Blessed One.

Then the Blessed One declared this: "Subhūti, here, those who have genuinely entered the vehicle of the bodhisattva should think thus: 'However many sentient beings there may be, in whatever categories of sentient beings they may be subsumed — those born from an egg, those born from a womb, those born from heat and moisture, those born miraculously; those with form or those without form; those with perception, those without perception, or those with neither perception nor non-perception; whatever the realm of sentient beings, however many may be designated under the designation of sentient being — all of these I shall lead to complete nirvāṇa in the realm of nirvāṇa that leaves no remainder of aggregates.'

And yet, even though innumerable sentient beings are thus led to nirvāṇa, one should generate the mind thinking: 'Not a single sentient being has been led to nirvāṇa.' And why is that? Subhūti, if a bodhisattva were to engage in the perception of sentient beings, he could not be called a bodhisattva. And why is that? Subhūti, whoever engages in the perception of sentient beings, or the perception of a living soul, or the perception of a person — such a one cannot be called a bodhisattva.

Furthermore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva should give gifts without abiding in anything. He should give without abiding in phenomena. He should give without abiding in form. He should give without abiding in sound, smell, taste, touch, or mental objects. Subhūti, a bodhisattva should give in such a way that he does not even abide in the perception of characteristics. And why? Subhūti, because the accumulation of merit of a bodhisattva who gives without abiding is not easy to measure.

Subhūti, what do you think? Is the expanse of space in the east easy to measure? Subhūti replied: Blessed One, it is not. The Blessed One declared: In the same way, the expanse of space in the south, the west, the north, above, below, the intermediate directions, and the space of all ten directions — is that easy to measure? Subhūti replied: Blessed One, it is not. The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, in just the same way, the accumulation of merit of a bodhisattva who gives without abiding is not easy to measure.

Subhūti, what do you think? Can the Tathāgata be seen by means of a perfect array of major marks? Subhūti replied: Blessed One, that is not so. The Tathāgata cannot be seen by means of a perfect array of major marks. And why? Because what the Tathāgata taught as a perfect array of major marks is, in truth, no perfect array of major marks at all.

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke these words to the Venerable Subhūti: Subhūti, to whatever extent there is a perfect array of major marks, to that same extent there is falsity. To whatever extent there is no perfect array of major marks, to that same extent there is no falsity. Thus should the Tathāgata be regarded in terms of both marks and no-marks.

When this was declared, the Venerable Subhūti said to the Blessed One: Blessed One, will there be any sentient beings who, in the last five-hundred-year period of the future, when the noble Dharma is utterly destroyed, will generate true understanding of the words of such a sūtra passage? The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, do not say it in that way —

asking whether there will be sentient beings who, in the last five-hundred-year period of the future, when the noble Dharma is utterly destroyed, will generate true understanding of the words of such a sūtra passage.

Rather, Subhūti, in that last five-hundred-year period of the future, when the noble Dharma is utterly destroyed, there will arise bodhisattvas, great beings, who are endowed with moral discipline, endowed with good qualities, and endowed with wisdom. Subhūti, these bodhisattvas, these great beings, will not have served and venerated just one buddha, nor will they have planted roots of virtue under just one buddha; rather, Subhūti, they will have served and venerated many hundreds and thousands of buddhas,

and planted roots of virtue under many hundreds and thousands of buddhas — such bodhisattvas, such great beings, will arise. Those who, upon hearing the words of such a sūtra passage, give rise to even a single moment of faith — those ones, Subhūti, are known by the Tathāgata. Subhūti, they are seen by the Tathāgata. All those sentient beings, Subhūti, will generate and fully gather an immeasurable accumulation of merit.

Why is that? Because, Subhūti, those bodhisattvas, those great beings, will not engage in the perception of a self, will not have the perception of a sentient being, will not have the perception of a life-force, and will not engage in the perception of a person. And, Subhūti, those bodhisattvas, those great beings, will not have the perception of a phenomenon, nor will they engage in the perception of the absence of phenomena. They will not engage in either perception or the absence of perception.

Why is that? Because, Subhūti, if those bodhisattvas, those great beings, were to engage in the perception of phenomena, that very thing would become their grasping at a self, their grasping at a sentient being, their grasping at a life-force, and their grasping at a person. And if they were to engage in the perception of the absence of phenomena, that too would become their grasping at a self, their grasping at a sentient being, their grasping at a life-force, and their grasping at a person.

Why is that? Because, Subhūti, a bodhisattva should not wrongly take hold of phenomena, and should not take hold of what is not a phenomenon. This is why the Tathāgata, having that in mind, declared: "Those who understand the categories of the Dharma as like a raft should let go of phenomena — how much more so what is not a phenomenon."

Furthermore, the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, what do you think? Is there any phenomenon by which the Tathāgata fully and perfectly awakened to the unsurpassable, truly complete awakening? Did the Tathāgata teach any phenomenon whatsoever?"

Having said this, the venerable Subhūti replied to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has said, there is no phenomenon whatsoever by which the Tathāgata fully and perfectly awakened to unsurpassable, truly complete awakening. Nor is there any phenomenon whatsoever that the Tathāgata has taught. Why is that? Because whatever the Tathāgata has fully and perfectly awakened to or taught is neither graspable nor expressible. It is neither a phenomenon nor the absence of a phenomenon. Why? Because noble persons are distinguished by the unconditioned."

The Blessed One then declared: "Subhūti, what do you think? If some son of good family or daughter of good family were to fill this great trichiliocosm with the seven kinds of precious things and give them as a gift, would that son of good family or daughter of good family thereby generate a great accumulation of merit?"

Subhūti replied: "A great accumulation, Blessed One. A great accumulation, Sugata. That son of good family or daughter of good family would thereby generate a great accumulation of merit. Why? Because, Blessed One, that very accumulation of merit is no accumulation at all — and that is why the Tathāgata speaks of an accumulation of merit as an accumulation of merit."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, whereas any son of good family or daughter of good family might fill this great trichiliocosm with the seven kinds of precious things and give them as a gift —"

— and whoever were to take even a single verse of four lines from this Dharma discourse and teach it, explain it, and expound it correctly to others, that person would thereby generate a far greater accumulation of merit from that basis — immeasurable and incalculable. And why is that? Subhūti, it is because the unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening of the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, issued forth from this, and because the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are likewise born from this. And why is that? Subhūti, because what are called "the qualities of a buddha" the Tathāgata has declared to be no qualities of a buddha at all — and that is why they are called "the qualities of a buddha."

Subhūti, what do you think? Does a stream-enterer (srotāpanna) think to himself, "I have attained the fruit of stream-entry"?

Subhūti replied: "No, Blessed One. And why not? Because there is nothing whatsoever that one who has entered the stream has entered — and that is why one is called a stream-enterer. One does not enter into form, into sound, into smell, into taste, into touch, or into phenomena — and that is why one is called a stream-enterer. Blessed One, if a stream-enterer were to think, 'I have attained the fruit of stream-entry,' that very thought would be a grasping at self, a grasping at a sentient being, a grasping at a life principle, and a grasping at a person."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what do you think? Does a once-returner (sakṛdāgāmin) think to himself, 'I have attained the fruit of once-returning'?"

Subhūti replied: "No, Blessed One. And why not? Because there is no dharma whatsoever that is the once-returning — and that is why one is called a once-returner."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what do you think? Does a non-returner (anāgāmin) think to himself, 'I have attained the fruit of non-return'?"

Subhūti replied: "No, Blessed One. And why not? Because there is no dharma whatsoever through which one has entered the state of non-returning — and that is why one is called a non-returner."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what do you think? Does an arhat think to himself, 'I have attained arhatship'?"

Subhūti replied: "No, Blessed One. And why not? Because there is no dharma whatsoever that is called an arhat. Blessed One, if an arhat were to think, 'I have attained arhatship,' that very thought would be a grasping at self, a grasping at a sentient being, a grasping at a life principle, and a grasping at a person. Blessed One, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, has declared me to be the foremost among those who dwell in the affliction-free state. Blessed One, I am an arhat freed from attachment — yet, Blessed One, I do not think to myself, 'I am an arhat.' Blessed One, if I were to think, 'I have attained arhatship,' the Tathāgata would not have said of me, 'The son of good family Subhūti is the foremost of those who dwell in the affliction-free state — because he abides in nothing at all, he is called one who dwells in the affliction-free state.'"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what do you think?"

"Is there any Dharma whatsoever that the Tathāgata received from the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Dīpaṃkara?"

Subhūti replied: "Blessed One, there is not. There is no Dharma whatsoever that the Tathāgata received from the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha Dīpaṃkara."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, if any bodhisattva were to say, 'I will bring about the adornment of buddha-fields,' that would be speaking falsely. And why? Subhūti, 'adornments of buddha-fields, adornments of buddha-fields' — the Tathāgata has taught that those adornments are no adornments at all; therefore they are called adornments of buddha-fields.

"Therefore, Subhūti, bodhisattvas, great beings, should arouse the mind in this way: without abiding. They should arouse the mind without abiding in anything whatsoever. They should arouse the mind without abiding in form. They should arouse the mind without abiding in sound, smell, taste, touch, or mental phenomena.

"Subhūti, consider this: suppose there were a person whose body became like this — like Mount Meru, the king of mountains. Subhūti, what do you think? Would that body be great?"

Subhūti replied: "Blessed One, that body would indeed be great. Sugata, that body would indeed be great. And why? The Tathāgata has taught that it is no thing — therefore it is called a body. The Tathāgata has taught that it is no thing, and therefore it is called a body."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what do you think? Suppose there were as many Ganges rivers as there are grains of sand in the Ganges — would the grains of sand in all those rivers be many?"

Subhūti replied: "Blessed One, even those Ganges rivers themselves would be exceedingly many — how much more so their grains of sand!"

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, you should have confidence in this; you should grasp it thoroughly. Suppose some man or woman were to fill with the seven precious substances as many world-systems as there are grains of sand in all those Ganges rivers, and were to offer that as a gift to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas. Subhūti, what do you think? Would that man or woman thereby generate a great abundance of merit?"

Subhūti replied: "Blessed One, they would generate a great abundance. Sugata, they would generate a great abundance — that man or woman would generate a great abundance of merit thereby."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, one who fills that many world-systems with the seven precious substances and gives them as a gift to the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly and completely awakened buddhas — compared to one who takes up even so much as a four-line verse from this Dharma discourse and teaches it fully and correctly to others, the latter generates merit more abundant still, beyond measure and beyond reckoning.

"Furthermore, Subhūti, whatever place a four-line verse from this Dharma discourse is recited or taught — that place becomes a shrine worthy of worship by the world with its gods, humans, and asuras. How much more so one who takes up this entire Dharma discourse, retains it, reads it, masters it, and applies it to mind in the proper way — that person will be endowed with the most wondrous excellence. In that place the Teacher himself is present, and other venerable presences dwell there as well."

When this was spoken,

the venerable Subhūti addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, what is the name of this Dharma discourse, and how should I take it up?"

When he had asked this, the Blessed One declared to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, this Dharma discourse is called the Perfection of Wisdom (prajñāpāramitā). Take it up by that name. And why? Subhūti, what the Tathāgata has taken up as the Perfection of Wisdom is, for that very reason, without perfection. Therefore it is called the Perfection of Wisdom."

"Subhūti, what do you think? Is there any Dharma whatsoever that the Tathāgata has taught?"

Subhūti replied: "Blessed One, there is no Dharma whatsoever that the Tathāgata has taught."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what do you think? Are the fine particles of dust in this great trichiliocosm (the triple thousand great thousand world-system) numerous?"

Subhūti replied: "Blessed One, those particles of dust are indeed numerous. They are indeed numerous, O Sugata (Well-Gone One, an epithet of the Buddha). And why? Blessed One, whatever are called particles of dust — those the Tathāgata has declared to be without dust-nature. Therefore they are

called particles of dust. And whatever is called a world-system — that the Tathāgata has declared to be without the nature of a world-system. Therefore it is called a world-system."

The Blessed One declared: "Subhūti, what do you think? Is the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, to be seen by means of the thirty-two marks of a great being?"

Subhūti replied: "Blessed One, no. And why? Whatever are those thirty-two marks of a great being that the Tathāgata has taught — those the Tathāgata has declared to be without mark-nature. Therefore they are called the thirty-two marks of the Tathāgata."

The Blessed One declared: "Furthermore, Subhūti, any man or woman who were to give up bodies as numerous as the grains of sand in the Gaṅgā river — and yet one who takes up even a single four-line verse from this Dharma discourse and teaches it to others — that one generates merit more abundant still, beyond measure and beyond reckoning."

Then the venerable Subhūti, moved by the power of the Dharma, shed tears. Having wiped away his tears, he addressed the Blessed One thus: "It is wonderful, Blessed One! It is wonderful, O Sugata, that the Tathāgata has taught this Dharma discourse. Blessed One, from the time my wisdom was born in me, never before have I heard a Dharma discourse such as this. Blessed One, those sentient beings who, upon hearing this sūtra being taught, give rise to genuine perception — they will be endowed with the most wondrous excellence. And why? Blessed One, what is called genuine perception is itself without the nature of perception. Therefore the Tathāgata speaks of it as genuine perception, genuine perception."

"Blessed One, as for me who is listening to this Dharma discourse being taught — for me to form faith and conviction in it requires no great wonder. But Blessed One, those sentient beings who, in the final age to come, in the last five hundred years, take up this Dharma discourse, retain it, read it, and bring it to thorough mastery — they will be endowed with the most wondrous excellence. Moreover, Blessed One, they will not engage in a perception of self, will not engage in a perception of sentient being, will not engage in a perception of life-force, and will not engage in a perception of person. And why? Blessed One, the perception of self, the perception of sentient being, the perception of life-force,

and the perception of person are themselves non-perceptions. And why? Because the buddhas, the Blessed Ones, are free from all perceptions.

When this was said, the Blessed One spoke these words to the venerable Subhūti: "Subhūti, that is exactly so, exactly so. Those sentient beings who do not tremble, do not grow frightened, and do not become terrified upon hearing this discourse will be endowed with the most wondrous excellence. And why? Subhūti, this supreme perfection (pāramitā) has been proclaimed by the Tathāgata — and this supreme perfection proclaimed by the Tathāgata has been proclaimed by immeasurable buddhas, the Blessed Ones. Therefore it is called the supreme perfection.

Furthermore, Subhūti, what the Tathāgata calls the perfection of patience is itself no perfection. And why? Subhūti, at the time when the king of Kalinga cut off my limbs and members, I had no perception of self, no perception of sentient being, no perception of life-force, and no perception of person. I had no perception of any kind, nor had I fallen into an absence of perception. And why? Subhūti, had I at that time had a perception of self, I would then also have had a perception of malice. Had I had a perception of sentient being, a perception of life-force, or a perception of person, I would then also have had a perception of malice. Subhūti, through direct knowledge I recall that in the past, over five hundred lifetimes, I dwelt as a sage called the Patient One — and even then, no perception of self arose in me, no perception of sentient being, no perception of life-force, and no perception of person arose in me.

Therefore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva (bodhisattva), a great being, having abandoned all perceptions entirely, should generate the mind set upon unsurpassed, perfect, and complete awakening. One should generate a mind that does not abide in form. One should generate a mind that does not abide in sound, smell, taste, touch, or phenomena. One should generate a mind that does not abide in the absence of phenomena. One should generate a mind that does not abide in anything whatsoever. And why? Whatever abides is precisely non-abiding. Therefore the Tathāgata has said: 'A bodhisattva should give gifts in a non-abiding manner.'

Furthermore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva should give gifts entirely for the sake of all sentient beings. And whatever perception of sentient being there is, that is itself a non-perception — for what the Tathāgata calls 'all sentient beings' is itself likewise nothing. And why? Subhūti, the Tathāgata speaks correctly, speaks truly, speaks of suchness — the Tathāgata speaks of suchness without

error.

Furthermore, Subhūti, with regard to any dharma that the Tathāgata has fully and perfectly awakened to, or takes up, there is in it neither truth nor falsehood.

Subhūti, consider this example: a person who possesses sight but has entered into darkness sees nothing at all — so too should one regard the bodhisattva who gives gifts while falling into the conception of something real. Subhūti, consider this further example: when dawn has broken and the sun has risen, a person who possesses sight sees the many and varied forms — so too should one regard the bodhisattva who gives gifts without falling into the conception of something real.

Furthermore, Subhūti, those sons of good family or daughters of good family who take up this enumeration of Dharma, retain it, read it, bring it to thorough mastery, and"

explain it in full detail to others — those ones are known by the Tathāgata, those ones are seen by the Tathāgata, and every one of those sentient beings will generate an immeasurable accumulation of merit.

Furthermore, Subhūti, should any man or woman, at the time of the morning session, give away a body of selves as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, and at the time of the midday session again give away a body of selves as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges, and at the time of the evening session likewise give away a body of selves as many as the grains of sand in the Ganges — and do so across hundreds of thousands of myriads of aeons of such a kind — yet someone else, upon hearing this enumeration of Dharma, does not reject it: then from that very basis alone the latter generates merit far more numerous, beyond counting, beyond measure. How much more, then, the one who writes it down, takes it up, retains it, reads it, brings it to thorough mastery, and explains it in full detail to others?

Subhūti, this enumeration of Dharma is inconceivable and incomparable. The Tathāgata has taught this enumeration of Dharma for the sake of sentient beings who have genuinely entered the supreme vehicle, and for the sake of sentient beings who have genuinely entered the most excellent vehicle. Those who take up this enumeration of Dharma, read it, bring it to thorough mastery, and explain it in full detail to others — those ones are known by the Tathāgata, those ones are seen by the Tathāgata, and every one of those sentient beings will come to possess an immeasurable accumulation of merit — an

accumulation of merit that is inconceivable, incomparable, immeasurable, and boundless. Every one of those sentient beings will carry upon their shoulders my awakening. Why is that? Subhūti, those devoted to the lesser cannot hear this enumeration of Dharma. Those who hold the view of a self cannot hear it, take it up, retain it, read it, or bring it to thorough mastery — and neither can those who hold the view of a sentient being, the view of a life-principle, or the view of a person. That is because there is no basis for it there.

Furthermore, Subhūti, whatever place this sūtra is taught, that place will be fit to be worshipped by the world together with its gods, humans, and asuras. That place will be fit to be venerated and circumambulated. That place will become like a stūpa.

Subhūti, those sons of good family or daughters of good family who take up the words of a sūtra such as this, retain them, read them, and bring them to thorough mastery — they will be afflicted; they will be greatly afflicted. Why is that? Subhūti, the non-virtuous actions those sentient beings committed in former lifetimes — actions that would have caused them to be born in a wretched state — through their being afflicted in this very life, those prior non-virtuous actions will be purified, and they will attain the awakening of a buddha.

Subhūti, I recall with direct knowledge that, in the past, across immeasurable aeons beyond even immeasurable aeons, beyond the far side of the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened Dīpaṃkara, there arose eighty-four hundred thousand myriads of buddhas, and I pleased every one of them, and having pleased them I did not cause them any dissatisfaction. Subhūti, compared with the merit accumulated through my having pleased those Blessed One buddhas without causing them dissatisfaction, whatever merit is generated by one who, in the final five-hundred-year period of the future age, takes up this sūtra, retains it, reads it, and brings it to thorough mastery — Subhūti, the former accumulation of merit does not amount to even a hundredth part of this accumulation of merit, not a thousandth part, not a hundred-thousandth part, not any fraction or portion, not any reckoning or division, not any count or comparison —

it does not bear comparison or calculation. Subhūti, if at that time the heaps of merit that those sons of good family or daughters of good family will have fully gathered — were I to declare how great that heap of merit is, sentient beings would become confused and their minds would be thrown into turmoil.

Furthermore, Subhūti, this classification of Dharma is inconceivable, and its karmic maturation likewise should be understood to be inconceivable.

Then the venerable Subhūti addressed the Blessed One with these words: Blessed One, how should one who has genuinely entered the bodhisattva vehicle abide? How should one practise? How should one take hold of the mind?

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, one who has genuinely entered the bodhisattva vehicle should arouse this thought: "I shall bring all sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa in the realm of nirvāṇa that leaves no remainder of aggregates." And yet, even though all sentient beings have thus been brought to complete nirvāṇa, not a single sentient being has actually been brought to complete nirvāṇa. Why is that? Subhūti, if a bodhisattva were to engage the perception of "sentient being," one could not call that person a bodhisattva. And if one were to engage the perception of a person, one could not call that person a bodhisattva either. Why? Because, Subhūti, there is no such thing whatsoever as what is called "one who has genuinely entered the bodhisattva vehicle."

Subhūti, what do you think? Is there any dharma by which the Tathāgata, from the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara, attained unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening?

When this was said, the venerable Subhūti replied to the Blessed One: Blessed One, there is no dharma whatsoever by which the Tathāgata, from the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara, attained unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening.

Upon hearing this, the Blessed One declared to the venerable Subhūti: Just so, Subhūti. Just so it is. There is no dharma whatsoever by which the Tathāgata attained unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening from the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara. Subhūti, if there were any dharma at all by which the Tathāgata had attained perfect and complete awakening, then the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara would not have given me this prophecy: "You, young brahmin, shall in a future age become the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened, Śākyamuni." Rather, Subhūti, precisely because the Tathāgata has attained unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening through no dharma whatsoever, the Tathāgata Dīpaṃkara gave me this prophecy: "You, young brahmin, shall in a future age become the Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened, Śākyamuni." Why is that? Subhūti, the term

"Tathāgata" is a synonym for genuine suchness. Subhūti, if anyone were to say, "The Tathāgata, arhat, perfectly and completely awakened, has attained unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening" — that person speaks falsely. Why? Because, Subhūti, there is no dharma whatsoever by which the Tathāgata has attained unsurpassable, perfect, and complete awakening.

Subhūti, in the awakening that the Tathāgata has fully and perfectly awakened to through no dharma whatsoever, there is neither truth nor falsehood. Therefore the Tathāgata has declared: "All phenomena are the Buddha's own phenomena." Subhūti, as for the phrase "all phenomena" — all of those are in fact no-phenomena; and therefore they are spoken of as "all phenomena, the Buddha's own phenomena."

Subhūti, it is like this: consider a person who has a body, and whose body has become great and vast. The venerable Subhūti asked: Blessed One, when the Tathāgata speaks of a person who "has a body and whose body is great and vast," the Tathāgata has declared that to be no-body. Therefore it is called "having a body, and a body that is great and vast."

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, exactly so. A bodhisattva who were to say, "I shall lead all sentient beings to complete nirvāṇa" — such a one should not be called a bodhisattva. Why is that? Subhūti, is there any dharma that goes by the name "bodhisattva"? Subhūti replied: No, Blessed One, there is not. The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, therefore the Tathāgata has declared that all phenomena are without a sentient being, without a life-force, and without a person.

Subhūti, a bodhisattva who were to say, "I shall accomplish the adornments of the buddha-fields" — that too should be spoken of in the same way. Why is that? Because the Tathāgata has declared that the adornments of the buddha-fields are in fact without adornment; therefore they are called "adornments of the buddha-fields."

Subhūti, a bodhisattva who has the conviction that "all phenomena are without self — phenomena are without self" — that one is declared by the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha to be a bodhisattva, a bodhisattva indeed.

Subhūti, what do you think? Does the Tathāgata possess the eye of flesh? Subhūti replied: Yes, Blessed One, it is so — the Tathāgata possesses the eye of flesh. The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, what do you think? Does the Tathāgata possess the divine eye? Subhūti replied: Yes, Blessed One, it is so —

the Tathāgata possesses the divine eye. The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, what do you think? Does the Tathāgata possess the eye of wisdom? Subhūti replied: Yes, Blessed One, it is so — the Tathāgata possesses the eye of wisdom. The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, what do you think? Does the Tathāgata possess the Dharma eye? Subhūti replied: Yes, Blessed One, it is so — the Tathāgata possesses the Dharma eye. The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, what do you think? Does the Tathāgata possess the Buddha eye? Subhūti replied: Yes, Blessed One, it is so — the Tathāgata possesses the Buddha eye.

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, what do you think? Suppose there were as many Ganges rivers as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges, and then suppose the number of grains of sand in all of those rivers combined were that many world-systems — would those world-systems be numerous? Subhūti replied: Yes, Blessed One, it is so — those world-systems would be very numerous. The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, all the sentient beings existing in those world-systems, with their many and varied streams of thought and intention — I know them all completely. Why is that?

Subhūti, what is called "a stream of thought" is called that because the Tathāgata has declared that it has no real stream. That is why it is called "a stream of thought." And why is that? Subhūti, past mind is not to be apprehended; future mind is not to be apprehended; and present mind is not to be apprehended. That is why.

Subhūti, what do you think? If someone were to fill this great trichiliocosm — this entire vast world-system of three thousand great thousand worlds — completely full of the seven precious substances and offer it as a gift, would that son or daughter of good family thereby generate a great amount of merit? Subhūti replied: Yes, Blessed One, a great amount. Yes, Sugata, a great amount. The Blessed One declared: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. That son or daughter of good family would thereby generate a vast accumulation of merit. And yet, Subhūti, if merit truly existed as a real accumulation, the Tathāgata would not have spoken of "a vast accumulation of merit." That is precisely why the Tathāgata speaks of it as a vast accumulation of merit.

Subhūti, what do you think? Should the Tathāgata be seen through a fully accomplished form body? Subhūti replied: No, Blessed One. The Tathāgata is not to be seen through a fully accomplished form body. Why is that? Blessed One, what the Tathāgata has called "a fully accomplished form body" — that

fully accomplished form body has been declared by the Tathāgata to be no real accomplishment. That is why it is called "a fully accomplished form body."

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, what do you think? Should the Tathāgata be seen through perfect possession of the major marks? Subhūti replied: No, Blessed One. The Tathāgata is not to be seen through perfect possession of the major marks. Why is that? What the Tathāgata has spoken of as "perfect possession of the major marks" has been declared by the Tathāgata to be no real possession of the major marks. That is why it is called "perfect possession of the major marks."

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, what do you think — should one suppose that the Tathāgata thinks, "I have taught Dharma"? Subhūti, do not see it that way. Why? Because whatever Dharma the Tathāgata has taught, there is nothing there at all. Subhūti, if someone were to say, "The Tathāgata has taught Dharma," that person would be misrepresenting me — grasping at what is nonexistent through a wrong understanding. Why is that? Subhūti, "teaching Dharma, teaching Dharma" — there is no such thing as a Dharma-teaching that could become an object of apprehension. That is why there is truly nothing there to call "teaching Dharma."

Then the venerable Subhūti said this to the Blessed One: Blessed One, in the future, will there be any sentient beings who, upon hearing such Dharma being taught, will come to have genuine confidence in it? The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, those beings are neither sentient beings nor non-sentient beings. Why is that? Subhūti, what is called "sentient beings" — the Tathāgata has declared that they are without the nature of sentient beings. That is why they are called "sentient beings."

Subhūti, what do you think? Is there any phenomenon whatsoever through which the Tathāgata awakened to unsurpassed, genuine, and complete awakening? The venerable Subhūti replied: Blessed One, there is no phenomenon whatsoever through which the Tathāgata awakened to unsurpassed, genuine, and complete awakening. The Blessed One declared: So it is, Subhūti, so it is. There is not even the slightest phenomenon there, nothing to be apprehended — and that is why it is called "unsurpassed, genuine, and complete awakening."

Moreover, Subhūti, that Dharma is one of equality:

in which there is nothing unequal — and that is why it is called "unsurpassed, genuine, and complete awakening." Unsurpassed, genuine, and complete

awakening is equal in being without self, without sentient being, without life-force, and without person. It is through all virtuous phenomena that one fully and completely awakens.

Subhūti, what are called "virtuous phenomena" — those very things have been declared by the Tathāgata to be without phenomenon. And that is why they are called "virtuous phenomena."

Moreover, Subhūti, if some son of good family or daughter of good family were to take up as many heaps of the seven precious substances as there are kings of mountains — Mount Meru — in the great trichiliocosm and offer them as a gift, and another were to take up even so much as a single four-line verse from this Perfection of Wisdom and teach it to others — the accumulation of merit from this latter surpasses the former even by a hundredfold; it is not matched even up to any numerical reckoning.

Subhūti, what do you think? Does the Tathāgata think, "I have liberated sentient beings"? Subhūti, you should not see it that way. Why? Because there are no sentient beings whatsoever whom the Tathāgata has liberated. Subhūti, if the Tathāgata were to liberate even a single sentient being, that would mean the Tathāgata himself grasped at self, grasped at sentient being, grasped at life-force, and grasped at person.

Subhūti, what is called "grasping at self" — the Tathāgata has declared that to be without grasping; yet ordinary childlike beings hold to it. Subhūti, what are called "ordinary childlike beings" — the Tathāgata has declared them to be without any being at all. And that is why they are called "ordinary childlike beings."

Subhūti, what do you think? Is the Tathāgata to be seen by means of the perfect assembly of major marks? The venerable Subhūti replied: Blessed One, that is not so; the Tathāgata is not to be seen by means of the perfect assembly of major marks. The Blessed One declared: So it is, Subhūti — the Tathāgata is not to be seen by means of the perfect assembly of major marks. Subhūti, if the Tathāgata were to be seen by means of the perfect assembly of major marks, then a wheel-turning king would also be a Tathāgata. Therefore the Tathāgata is not to be seen by means of the perfect assembly of major marks.

Then the venerable Subhūti addressed the Blessed One in these words: Blessed One, as I understand the meaning of what the Blessed One has taught, the Tathāgata is not to be seen by means of the perfect assembly of

major marks.

At that time the Blessed One proclaimed these verses:

Those who see me in form,
those who know me through sound —
they have set out on a mistaken path;
those beings do not see me.

Buddhas are to be seen through the nature of reality;
the guides are the dharmakāya, the truth body.
The nature of reality cannot be an object of cognition —
therefore it cannot be known through consciousness.

Subhūti, what do you think? If one were to hold that the Tathāgata, the arhat, the genuinely and completely awakened buddha is known through the perfect assembly of major marks — Subhūti, you should not see it that way. The Tathāgata, the arhat, the genuinely and completely awakened buddha does not awaken to unsurpassed, genuine, and complete awakening by means of the perfect assembly of major marks.

Subhūti, what do you think? If those who have genuinely entered the bodhisattva vehicle were to think that some phenomenon is destroyed or cut off — Subhūti, you should not see it that way. Those who have genuinely entered the bodhisattva vehicle do not regard any phenomenon as destroyed or

cut off. Furthermore, Subhūti, if a son of good family or a daughter of good family were to fill as many world-systems as there are grains of sand in the river Gaṅgā with the seven precious substances and give them as a gift — a bodhisattva who attains patient acceptance of the fact that all phenomena are without self and without arising generates from that very basis a far greater accumulation of merit.

Furthermore, Subhūti, a bodhisattva should not take up and hold an accumulation of merit as one's own.

The venerable Subhūti asked: Blessed One, should a bodhisattva not take up and hold an accumulation of merit?

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, one may indeed take it up and hold it, yet one should not grasp it wrongly — and therefore it is called "taking up and holding."

Subhūti, if someone were to say, "The Tathāgata goes somewhere, or comes, or rises, or sits, or lies down" — that person does not understand the meaning of what I have taught. Why? Because what is called the Tathāgata has not gone anywhere and has not come from anywhere — and therefore the Tathāgata, the arhat, the genuinely and completely awakened buddha is so called.

Furthermore, Subhūti, if a son of good family or a daughter of good family were to take all the dust-motes present in this great trichiliocosm — the great world-system of the three-thousand-fold universe — and grind them to a fine powder, Subhūti, what do you think? Would that mass of fine particles be great?

Subhūti replied: Blessed One, it would indeed be so — that mass of fine particles would be great. Why? Blessed One, if it truly existed as a mass, the Blessed One would not have spoken of it as a mass of fine particles. And why is that? Because what the Tathāgata has spoken of as a mass of fine particles, the Tathāgata has taught as being not a mass — and therefore it is called a mass of fine particles.

And what the Tathāgata has spoken of as the great world-system of the three-thousand-fold universe, the Tathāgata has taught as being not a world-system — and therefore it is called the great world-system of the three-thousand-fold universe. Why? Blessed One, if a world-system truly existed, it would be grasped as a solid lump. And what the Tathāgata has taught as grasping as a solid lump, the Tathāgata has taught as being not a grasping — and therefore it is called grasping as a solid lump.

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, grasping as a solid lump is merely a conventional expression, and that phenomenon is inexpressible — yet it is taken up and held by childish, ordinary beings.

Subhūti, if someone were to say, "The Tathāgata has spoken of a view of self, the Tathāgata has spoken of a view of sentient beings, a view of a living soul, and a view of a person" — Subhūti, would that be speaking correctly?

Subhūti replied: No, Blessed One, it would not. No, Sugata, it would not. Why? Blessed One, because what the Tathāgata has spoken of as a view of self, the Tathāgata has taught as being not a view — and therefore it is called a view of self.

The Blessed One declared: Subhūti, one who has genuinely entered the vehicle of the bodhisattva should know all phenomena in this way, should see them, should resolve upon them — in such a way that one does not abide even in the perception of "phenomenon." Why?

Subhūti, "the perception of a phenomenon, the perception of a phenomenon" — this is something the Tathāgata has taught as being not a perception; and therefore it is called the perception of a phenomenon.

And further, Subhūti, whatever bodhisattva, a great being, were to fill immeasurable and uncountable world-systems with the seven kinds of precious things and give them as a gift — compared to that, if a son of good family or a daughter of good family were to take even so much as a four-line verse from this Perfection of Wisdom, and hold it, or read it, or master it fully, or teach it in detail and correctly to others — on that very basis they would generate merit that is far greater, immeasurable, and uncountable.

And how does one teach it correctly? One teaches it correctly by teaching it as though one were not teaching it at all — and therefore it is called teaching correctly.

A star, a visual distortion, a lamp,
an illusion, a dewdrop, a water bubble,
a dream, a flash of lightning, a cloud —
see all that is conditioned in just this way.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the Elder Subhūti, and those bodhisattvas, and the fourfold assembly of monks, nuns, laymen, and laywomen, and the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas — all the world rejoiced and offered heartfelt praise for what the Blessed One had taught.

This completes the noble sūtra of the Great Vehicle known as the Perfection of Wisdom: the Diamond Cutter.

Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered as "the garden of Anāthapiṇḍada" translates the Tibetan "mgon med zas sbyin gyi kun dga' ra ba," literally "the pleasure grove of Anāthapiṇḍada," referring to the benefactor Anāthapiṇḍada (the "feeder of the shelterless") who donated the Jeta Grove to the Buddha. This is standard and unproblematic.

The closing sentence of the passage is the opening of the Buddha's answer and is deliberately left incomplete, as the Tibetan passage itself ends mid-sentence before the conclusion of the instruction. The translation renders exactly what is present in the source without completing or supplying the missing conclusion.

- The phrase rendered "true understanding" translates a construction meaning literally "generating the correct perception" of the sūtra passage — that is, recognizing it rightly rather than merely intellectually assenting to it. This is consistent with Perfection of Wisdom diction throughout.

The passage on marks employs a deliberate dialectical structure: what is called a perfect array of marks is, precisely by being a designatable array, already not an ultimate array. The translation preserves this logic faithfully without smoothing it into a simpler claim.

- The raft simile is a well-known reference to the canonical parable in which the Dharma, having served its purpose of crossing to the other shore, is to be left behind rather than carried on one's head. The Tibetan here does not spell out the full parable but assumes the listener's familiarity with it.

The phrase rendered "noble persons are distinguished by the unconditioned" translates a compact Tibetan clause meaning that what sets ārya beings apart is precisely their realization of the unconditioned (asaṃskṛta), i.e., nirvāṇa or dharmatā. Some editions read this slightly differently, but the doctrinal sense is consistent across witnesses.

- The phrase translated as "the affliction-free state" renders a term literally meaning "dwelling without affliction" or "abiding in non-contention" — the Tibetan here corresponds to the Sanskrit araṇāvihāra, a specialized term designating a meditative quality or attainment associated with the arhat Subhūti, said to be foremost in this quality. The rendering "affliction-free state" captures both the absence of kleśa and the technical sense of araṇā without requiring an opaque transliteration.

The four-line verse mentioned at the opening continues the gift-comparison motif from the preceding passage; the Tibetan does not repeat the full protasis but assumes the context of the great trichilocosm gift already stated.

- The phrase rendered "other venerable presences dwell there as well" translates a somewhat compressed Tibetan expression. The sense in the commentarial tradition is that, in a place where such a text is present and taught, it functions as if a teacher or guru were dwelling there — the passage is likely referring to the text itself serving as a locus of the Buddha's presence, alongside the literal meaning that spiritually accomplished beings are drawn to such a place.

- The phrase rendered "genuine perception" translates yang dag par 'du shes, literally "correct / authentic perception." The Tathāgata's remark that this "genuine perception is itself without perception-nature" follows the characteristic Diamond Sūtra dialectic: the label is applied precisely because the referent transcends the ordinary reification implied by the label. The rendering "genuine perception" is chosen to preserve both the positive affirmation and the subsequent negation.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the supplied Tibetan, cutting off after the enumeration of the four perceptions (self, sentient being, life-force, person); the translation faithfully follows the text to where it breaks off.

- The phrase rendered "falling into the conception of something real" translates the Tibetan "dngos por lhung ba," literally "falling into a thing," meaning clinging to objects as having inherent existence. This is a standard Madhyamaka formulation and the rendering reflects the doctrinal sense accurately.

The passage ends mid-sentence in the supplied Tibetan, as it continues into the next portion of the text.

- The phrase rendered "carry upon their shoulders my awakening" translates a metaphor of bearing awakening on one's shoulders, conveying that such practitioners become vessels or

bearers of buddhahood — a standard formulation in the Diamond Sūtra tradition indicating that they embody and propagate the Buddha's enlightenment.

The passage breaks mid-sentence at the end, consistent with the continuity format; the list of fractional comparisons is deliberately left incomplete as in the source.

- The phrase rendered "a synonym for genuine suchness" translates the Tibetan "yang dag pa de bzhin nyid kyi tshig bla dgas yin pa," which is slightly elliptical. The sense is that "Tathāgata" is an expression or synonym for genuine suchness (tathatā), meaning the one who has "thus gone" or "thus come" in accordance with reality itself. This is a standard Madhyamaka gloss on the etymology of the epithet and is preserved faithfully here.

The term "leaves no remainder of aggregates" (Skt. nirupadhiśeṣanirvāṇadhātu) refers to the complete nirvāṇa in which no psychophysical constituents persist — the final nirvāṇa distinguished from the nirvāṇa with remainder.

- The five eyes listed here follow the canonical sequence: the eye of flesh, the divine eye, the eye of wisdom, the Dharma eye, and the Buddha eye. This is a standard doctrinal enumeration in Prajñāpāramitā literature and no special note is required beyond confirming the rendering is consistent with tradition.

The phrase rendered "streams of thought and intention" translates the Tibetan for the many and varied mental continua of beings, a reference to the Tathāgata's ability to directly know the minds of all sentient beings — one of his supernormal knowledges.

- The phrase rendered "a stream of thought" translates sems kyi rgyud, literally "continuum of mind." The passage is playing on the technical sense of rgyud as mental continuum and the colloquial meaning of "stream." The Tathāgata's declaration that it "has no real stream" (rgyud med pa) is the characteristic Diamond Sūtra rhetorical reversal: the conventional designation is upheld precisely because the referent lacks inherent existence.

The closing line "that Dharma is one of equality" ends mid-sentence in the source passage, which itself breaks off mid-thought. This is noted as a passage boundary, not an error in translation.

- The phrase rendered "ordinary childlike beings" translates the Tibetan term for common, immature worldlings — beings who have not yet entered the noble path. The compound carries a sense of spiritual immaturity rather than literal childhood.

The final sentence of the passage is syntactically incomplete in the source text as given, trailing off mid-construction. The translation reflects this, ending where the Tibetan ends.

- The phrase rendered "grasping as a solid lump" translates the Tibetan "ril por 'dzin pa," corresponding to Sanskrit piṇḍagrāha — taking the world-system as a single, substantial, cohesive entity. The philosophical point is that both the world-system and its constituent particles lack inherent existence as the aggregates they nominally designate; grasping either as a compact reality is itself a form of reification. This is a standard Perfection of Wisdom dialectic and the rendering aims to preserve the concrete image the text employs.

- The closing verse's six-plus images follow the classical list found in Sanskrit manuscripts of the Vajracchedikā, though different recensions enumerate slightly different terms. The Tibetan here reads: star, visual distortion (rab rib, often "film over the eye" or "floater"), lamp, illusion, dewdrop, water bubble, dream, lightning, cloud — nine images total, which matches well-known Sanskrit versions.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.